

THE WONDER
Spencer's store in Madras, 1967; (inset) Spencer's Plaza, India's first shopping mall



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THE MALL MANIA

Shopping malls, a 1990s innovation in India, changed the way the Indian middle class shops. Their success now lies in being 'shoppertainment' destinations, offering something for everyone

BY SONAL KHETARPAL

Spencer Plaza was India's first shopping mall when it opened in 1991 on Chennai's Mount Road. Built on the 10-acre site of a late 19th century Indo-Saracenic architectural landmark—itself a department store which had some 80 shops when it first started—that had burnt to the ground in a fire in 1983, it was an instant hit with Chennaiites, as much for the glitzy shops as an escape from the torpor and heat (central air-conditioning was still a novelty). This was the country's first mega mall, a precursor to the concrete and glass, temperature-controlled transformation of Indian retail shopping that has swept through the metros and B-towns of the country.

The malls have revolutionised the way India's middle-class shops. Compared to the crowded bazaars of, say, Chandni Chowk in Delhi or Heera Panna in Mumbai, they offered neatly stacked stores, air-conditioned premises, easy movement with escalators and elevators, and Indians, at least of a certain class, were quick to embrace the change. Beyond shopping, malls also soon started providing food courts, cinemas and other enter-